

Sibling Rivalry Goes Global: Brothers Could Clash at the World Cup

From: BBC News Mined: 2026-06-20 5 min read

It's the ultimate test for any parent: two sons on opposite teams in a match. But this isn't a local park kickabout it's the World Cup. Desire and Guela Doue, born in Angers, France, to a French mother and an Ivorian father, have taken different paths in international football. Desire, 21, a two-time Champions League winner with Paris Saint-Germain, represents France. Guela, 23, an **overlapping full-back** for Strasbourg, plays for Ivory Coast. "We tell each other everything and have no secrets," Desire told French TV show Telefoot. "He's such a massive support for me in my daily life." But their close bond could be tested on June 30 in Arlington, Texas. If France finishes second in Group I and Ivory Coast second in Group E, the brothers will face each other in the **round of 32**. The prospect isn't far-fetched: in a pre-World Cup friendly on June 4, Ivory Coast beat France 2-1. Guela sang both national anthems before kickoff, but Desire was an **unused substitute**. "It's a shame I didn't get to play against my brother," Guela said afterward. "But I'm happy, and he isn't too fed up." The Doues are not alone. This World Cup features four sets of siblings playing for different nations. The most famous **precedent** is the **Boateng brothers**: Jerome for Germany and Kevin-Prince for Ghana, who faced each other in the 2010 and 2014 World Cups. Inaki and Nico Williams, both born in the **Basque Country** and teammates at Athletic Bilbao, are another pair. Inaki chose Ghana, Nico chose Spain. For the Doue family, the possibility of a head-to-head clash is thrilling and agonizing. Who will their parents support? Perhaps both, hoping for a draw and no injuries. As Desire and Guela know, football is about family, even when you're on opposite sides.

Word Treasure

overlapping full-back -- A soccer defender who pushes high up the field to join attacks, often sprinting past the winger to cross the ball.

precedent -- An earlier event or action that is used as an example or guide for what might happen in a similar future situation.

Boateng brothers -- Jerome and Kevin-Prince Boateng, the famous siblings who played for Germany and Ghana and faced each other at the 2010 and 2014 World Cups.

Basque Country -- An autonomous region in northern Spain with its own language and culture, known for strong local identity and a major football club, Athletic Bilbao.

unused substitute -- A player who sits on the bench during a match but is never sent onto the field by the coach.

round of 32 -- The first knockout stage of a World Cup tournament, where 32 teams compete in 16 do-or-die matches to reach the round of 16.

Background you need

The 2026 FIFA World Cup, co-hosted by the United States, Canada, and Mexico, introduced an expanded format with 48 teams and a round of 32 knockout stage, increasing the chances of unusual match-ups like siblings clashing.

AT&T Stadium in Arlington, Texas, where the potential Doue face-off could happen, is a domed venue with a retractable roof that holds over 80,000 fans and is home to the Dallas Cowboys American football team.

The Boateng brothers are the most famous real-life example: in 2010, half-brothers Jérôme (for Germany) and Kevin-Prince (for Ghana) became the first siblings to play against each other in a World Cup match, and they did so again in 2014, a moment that divided family loyalties and went down in football history.

Athletic Bilbao, the club where the Williams brothers are teammates, has a unique policy of only signing players born or raised in the Basque Country (an autonomous region in northern Spain), which makes it especially notable that Inaki chose Ghana while Nico chose Spain.

Under FIFA rules, a player with dual nationality can switch their international allegiance as long as they haven't played a competitive senior match for their first country, which is why some brothers end up on different national teams.

Break it down

LEAD: A parent's ultimate test -- two sons on opposite teams, but this time at the World Cup.

PLAYER INTRODUCTIONS: Desire Doue (21, two-time Champions League winner with Paris Saint-Germain) and Guela Doue (23, overlapping full-back for Strasbourg).

+ - FAMILY BOND: Desire says they tell each other everything and Guela is a massive support.

+ - NATIONAL CHOICE: Desire chose France, Guela chose Ivory Coast.

THE COLLISION SCENARIO: If France finishes second in Group I and Ivory Coast second in Group E, they meet in the round of 32 in Arlington, Texas on June 30.

+ - REASON TO BELIEVE: A recent friendly where Ivory Coast beat France 2-1 -- and Guela sang both anthems but Desire stayed on the bench.

WIDER PATTERN: This World Cup features four sets of siblings on different nations.

HISTORICAL PRECEDENT: The Boateng brothers (Germany/Ghana) faced each other in 2010 and 2014; also the Williams brothers (Ghana/Spain).

EMOTIONAL CLOSING: The agonizing question -- who do the parents cheer for? -- and the idea that football is about family, even on opposite sides.

Why it matters

As more players have dual nationality, these family splits at the highest level of sport will become more common, raising questions about identity and belonging -- issues that might echo in your own life if you or your friends are growing up with roots in more than one culture.

Test what you remember

1. Which two countries could the Doue brothers face each other for in the round of 32?
 - (A) France and Ghana
 - (B) France and Ivory Coast
 - (C) Spain and Ivory Coast
 - (D) Germany and France
2. What must happen in the group stage for the brothers to meet?
 - (A) Both teams must win their groups.
 - (B) France must finish second in Group I and Ivory Coast second in Group E.
 - (C) Ivory Coast must finish first and France first in their groups.
 - (D) The brothers must both ask FIFA to arrange the match.
3. What happened in the pre-World Cup friendly between France and Ivory Coast on June 4?
 - (A) France won 2-1.
 - (B) Ivory Coast won 2-1.
 - (C) The match ended in a 0-0 draw.
 - (D) Both brothers scored a goal.
4. Why didn't the brothers play against each other in that friendly?
 - (A) Guela was injured.
 - (B) Desire was an unused substitute.
 - (C) Both were suspended.
 - (D) The coach decided not to select either brother.
5. Which pair of siblings is the most famous precedent mentioned in the article?
 - (A) The Williams brothers
 - (B) The Doue brothers
 - (C) The Boateng brothers
 - (D) The Pezeshkian brothers
6. According to the article, what does Guela Doue say about his relationship with Desire?
 - (A) They rarely speak because of football.
 - (B) They tell each other everything and have no secrets.
 - (C) They argue all the time about their national teams.
 - (D) They haven't seen each other in years.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive (celebration of heritage):** The brothers' story shows how sport can honor multiple identities at once: playing for different nations doesn't erase a close family bond, and fans get to see a deeply human story that connects countries who might otherwise have little in common.
- 2. Negative / critical (strains and conflict):** When brothers become opponents, the pressure could crack even the strongest relationship. The agony for parents caught between their children, and the possibility that a bad tackle or a crucial mistake by one brother leads to blame or hard feelings, reveals the hidden emotional cost of representing different flags.
- 3. Neutral / analytical (a growing trend):** The pattern of siblings on different national teams is part of a wider shift: globalization and looser FIFA eligibility rules mean players increasingly choose the country that offers them the best career path, not necessarily the one they feel deepest loyalty to. This makes international football more like club football, where national identity becomes a strategic choice.
- 4. Forward-looking (what this means for the future):** If the Doue brothers clash, it will inspire more dual-nationality players to explore similar paths, but it could also lead FIFA to tighten some rules or encourage more tournaments designed to showcase players' mixed heritage. For young fans, seeing brothers on opposite sides might make them think about their own divided loyalties -- and maybe push them to define themselves beyond a single flag.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):
